

kids don't care about their extended family when they're teenagers, but they'll really start to value them later in life.

You don't have to plan an extravagant sojourn to Maui for your son or daughter's 13th birthday—in fact I'd advise against it. The whole point is to remind them they are *not* the center of the universe. You don't even have to go far; you could just as easily have your child invite some people over for a backyard BBQ.

Age 14

The DIY Birthday

The day your child turns 14, you're going to hand over the reins. Let her plan her own birthday party. Set a fair budget and give her license to do anything she wants (within reason), as long as it doesn't violate the parameters you've set or the law. If she decides to go all out—say, she wants to rent a party boat and take all her friends out on the lake—tell her that she's responsible for any costs that go over budget. If she's been working and saving for the last few years, she'll have access to her own funds, and if she insists on having a big bash, then she'll need to front the extra cash herself.

A lot of 14-year-olds won't respond kindly to having to pay for their own birthday party. But *your* 14-year-old is different, right? You've spent the last 10 years teaching her how to save and invest and be fiscally responsible instead of thinking of you as her personal wallet. She's been juggling odd jobs for years, socking her money away in her own savings and investment accounts (and monitoring them closely). She's growing her Secret 10 in stocks and securities that pay dividends and interest. She knows *exactly* how much money she has, and exactly how much she can afford to spend.

My kids have often opted for low-key birthday celebrations. Trevor loves steak, so we'll take a couple of his closest friends and head to a local steakhouse. Savannah loves Thai food, so she'll invite some friends over and we'll order takeout. Some of the best birthday memories at our house have been simple, inexpensive affairs. Who knows? Maybe your child will decide to blow a big chunk of change on her DIY birthday. But maybe—just maybe—